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Cairnly

Cairnly sells supply forecasting and multi-distributor ordering software to independent US dental practices, priced per location per month.

Cairnly targets a real cross-distributor ordering gap at independent dental practices, but traction is five paying customers and savings data is internal, n=5.

Evidence for the thesis: Partially supported. Sources document the workflow and its failures well through 22 interviews, but proof that Cairnly wins and holds customers rests on 5 paying practices and an internal n=5 savings figure, with distributor access untested.

How customers solve it today

In independent practices, the office manager orders supplies alongside front desk work. She walks the supply closet, updates a spreadsheet, and largely accepts the distributor rep's suggested reorder monthly. Gaps are filled from Amazon Business or a second distributor at retail prices, and invoices are matched by hand at month end. The deck puts this at about 5 hours a week, on spend of 6-8% of revenue. 17 of 22 interviewed practices use two or more distributors.

Source: Deck s.2, 3; Cairnly customer interviews p.2

Why those approaches fail

The core failure is who writes the order. The distributor's rep suggests the reorder, and the office manager lacks time and data to challenge it. None of 22 interviewed practices forecast usage from the schedule, so stockouts appear only when the closet is empty: 3 critical-item stockouts per quarter; one owner rescheduled patients. No tool sees total spend across sources, and her absence halts ordering. The owner bears the cost but not the work, which likely explains why the rep's default persists.

Source: Deck s.2, 3; Cairnly customer interviews p.1, 2

The alternatives a customer weighs

Alternative	Who uses it, and how	Where it breaks	Source
Spreadsheet and supply-closet walk status quo	Office manager counts the closet and updates a spreadsheet alongside front desk duties.	Depends on one person and one computer; no usage forecast, so critical items run out.	Deck s.3, 6; Cairnly customer interviews p.2
Distributor rep and ordering portal incumbent	Rep visits monthly and suggests the reorder; portal is free with the distributor account.	Locked to one catalog; the seller writes the order and nobody has time to check it.	Deck s.3, 6; Cairnly customer interviews p.1
Group purchasing organizations adjacent tool	Negotiate member discounts with suppliers on behalf of practices.	Addresses price only; the office manager still counts, orders and reconciles by hand.	Deck s.6
Horizontal inventory apps adjacent tool	Generic stock tracking for practices wanting something beyond a spreadsheet.	No link to the procedure schedule, so they track stock without forecasting use.	Deck s.6

Market structure

Two national distributors control most supply distribution, each with its own ordering portal, so the free tool every practice has is built to keep orders in one catalog. Group purchasing organizations negotiate price without touching ordering. DSOs are consolidating practices and centralizing purchasing, squeezing independents on price. That gives independents a reason to buy Cairnly, though consolidation may shrink their pool (inference). Cairnly estimates about 135,000 US practices, roughly 70% independent; this company estimate is unverified.

Source: Deck s.5, 6

Where the wedge emerges

Cairnly targets multi-distributor independents lacking purchasing teams. It forecasts usage from practice-management schedules and orders across distributors at contracted prices, unlike single-catalog portals, price-only GPOs or schedule-blind apps. The CEO ran operations for 8 years at a 30-location dental group. Evidence is thin: 14 pilots, 5 paying $249 per location monthly, and 11% savings over 90 days (internal data, five practices). Unverified: distributors continuing to permit third-party ordering, integration coverage, and savings beyond one quarter. Slide 8 was unreadable.

Source: Deck s.4, 6, 7, 9; Cairnly customer interviews p.2

What the materials do not show

- No evidence distributors permit third-party ordering or share contracted prices with Cairnly.
- Savings figure is internal, 90 days, five practices; no baseline method or retention data.
- No practice management system integration coverage shown; supported systems are unstated.
- Slide 8 unreadable; no win/loss data against distributor portals or GPOs.

Questions for the founder

- How do distributors respond when Cairnly places orders, and is contracted pricing access secured in writing?
- Of 14 pilots, why have only 5 converted to paid, and what did the other 9 say?
- Which practice management systems do you integrate with, and what share of independents do they cover?

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